Studiorum Ducem — historical abridged English translation

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ENCYCLICAL OF PIUS XI

on

THE SIXTH CENTENARY OF THE CANONIZATION OF ST. THOMAS AQUINAS

(Studiorum Ducem)

We have commanded that St. Thomas Aquinas be followed as the principal guide in teaching the subject-matter of the higher studies to all clerics. This We did in an apostolic letter written some time ago in which We confirmed all that has been laid down in Canon Law in this regard. As the day approaches when We are to celebrate the Sixth Centenary of his canonization there is offered Us a beautiful opportunity to insist upon this matter somewhat more in detail and to make known to all in what manner they can profit best by the teachings of this great master. Since true science and piety, the companions of all the virtues, are so wonder- fully joined together, and since God is both Infinite Truth and Infinite Goodness, assuredly it is not suf- ficient in order to promote the glory of God by the salvation of souls—the principal and peculiar work of the Church—that the clergy be merely well instructed

in knowledge, but that they possess at the same time and in abundance, all those virtues proper to their state of life. This union of knowledge and piety, of learning and virtue, of truth and love, was the posses- sion of the Angelic Doctor in a remarkable degree, so much so that it has been customary to represent him accompanied by a figure of the syn, for the reason that while he brings to the intellect the light of knowledge he increases at the same time in the will the flame of virtue.

It appears that God, the Source of all wisdom and holiness, wished to demonstrate in the person of Thomas how these two are complementary; how, for example, the exercise of virtue disposes the mind to contemplation of the truth, and how a profound con- templation of the truth, in its turn, renders the exercise of virtue the more noble and perfect. For whosoever leads a pure and upright life, whosoever holds his pas- sions in check by means of virtuous living, can, like a man freed from a heavy burden, lift himself the more easily to the meditation of heavenly things, and can fix his mind better on the profound secrets of God, ac- cording to the words of St. Thomas himself, who wrote: "Life precedes knowledge; it is life that leads us to a knowledge of the truth." (Commentary on Matthew, Chap. V) If a man give himself up completely to the study of supernatural truths, he will thereby feel impelled more and more to a life of pefection. Such knowledge, the beauty of which charms and attracts

the whole man, certainly cannot be said to be dry and impractical; on the contrary, it is supremely practical.

These are the lessons, Venerable Brothers, which this Centenary imparts. In order to make them better known, We thought it well to write briefly of the sanctity and learning of Thomas Aquinas and to point out to you what salutary teachings one can find in this subject, both for the priesthood, especially for the junior clergy, and for the entire Christian people.

St. Thomas possessed all the moral virtues in the highest possible degree, These virtues were so interrelated and so inter-connected that, as he himself desired, they were bound together by that charity which "gives the form to the acts of all the virtues." (II-II, Q. XXITI, ad. 8; I-II, Q. LXV) When, however, we set out to discover the very special characteristics of his sanctity, we will find them first of all in that virtue by which Thomas seemed to resemble most the angels, that is to say, in his chastity, which virtue he had preserved under most trying circumstances and because of which fact he was found worthy to be girded by angels with a mystic cincture. There was at the same time joined to his exquisite purity a detachment from the goods of this world and a despisal of its honors. It is well known with what heroic constancy he overcame the obstinate and continued attempts of his relatives to com- pel him to remain in the world; it is also no less well known how, even when the Supreme Pontiff had of-

fered him the dignity of the episcopate, he begged the Pope not to insist upon placing upon his shoulders such formidable burdens. But the main characteristic of the holiness of St. Thomas is that which St. Paul has called "the word of wisdom" (I Cor. xii, 8) that is to say, the union in him of the twofold wisdom, infused and acquired, as they are called. With these two virtues certainly no others harmonize so well as humility, love of prayer, and love of God.

With reference to humility which must be looked upon as the foundation of all the virtues of St. Thomas, this virtue is shown best in his life by the fact that he lived under obedience to a mere lay

brother. His humil- ity is also manifested strikingly in his writings, all of which exhibit a wonderful spirit of reverence for the Fathers of the Church. "As he held the ancient Doc- tors of the Church in the highest reverence,.so it seems that he was the heir to all their knowledge." (Leo XIII quoting Cardinal Cajetan in the Encyclical terni Patris.) His humility is also shown in a forceful manner by the fact that he used all the power of his super- human genius only to win triumphs for the truth, with- out in the least seeking to enhance his own reputation. While philosophers labor to increase their own fame, he studied how to keep himself out of his teachings so that the light of divine truth might shine forth from them all the more brilliantly. Meanwhile, this humility, which was united with purity of heart and a remark- able assiduity in prayer, made of the soul of Thomas

a docile and willing instrument by means of which he might both receive and follow the lights and inspira- tions of the Holy Spirit, in which the very essence of contemplation consists. In order to obtain these graces from heaven it was his custom often to abstain from all food before study, to pass whole nights in prayer, and, from time to time, moved by a truly child-like faith, to lean his head against the tabernacle of the altar as well as sorrowing to turn his eyes towards the image of Jesus Crucified from which book he learned all that he knew, as he himself con- fessed to his friend, St. Bonaventure. Of St. Thomas it can truly be said what had been previously said of his Father and Mas- ter, Dominic, that he spoke only with and about God.

As St. Thomas was accustomed to view everything in God, the first cause and final end of all things, it be- came easy for him to follow both in the doctrines of the Summa Theologica as well as in his private life, the way of that twofold wisdom which he has so well defined. "By way of our acquired wisdom which we obtain through study, we can pass sound judgments on the things of God if we use reason in a perfect man- ner. But there is another road to wisdom, a road which starts from on high . . . and judges the things of God by a kind of wisdom which is of the selfsame nature as the very objects it considers. Such wisdom is a gift of the Holy Ghost . . . by means of which one becomes perfect in the things of God, not only understanding

but even experiencing them in himself." (II-II, Q. XLV, Art. 1, Ad. 2 and Art 2, c)

This divine wisdom which Thomas possessed by in- fusion from on High, and, which in his soul, was ac- companied by the other gifts of the Holy Ghost, was constantly on the increase in much the same fashion as was his charity, mistress and cueen of all the vir- tues. He believed implicitly in the doctrine that love of God should constantly grow in our souls, following the rule set down in the First Precept of the law: "Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with thy whole heart; because the whole and the perfect are one and the same. . . . The end of the commandment is love, as the Apostle teaches." (I Timothy i, 5) "Now, there are no limitations where the end is concerned but only in those things which help us to attain an end." (II-II, Q. CLXXXIV, Art. 3) For this reason the attainment of perfect charity is a matter of commandment; such perfection is the end towards which all must aspire, each according to his state of life. Since "the peculiar effect of love is that man tends toward God by unit- ing himself with Him through his affections for the reason that he no longer lives to himself but for God alone" (II-II, Q. XVII, Art. 6, Ad. 3), we can see how in Thomas divine love, together with the twofold wis- dom already referred to, increased in such measure that it begot in him a complete forgetfulness of self. So great in fact was the effect of his love that to Jesus

Crucified who had said to him, "Thomas, thou hast written well of me. What reward dost thou ask?" the Saint replied, "Nothing else but Thee, Lord." Inspired by such love, he gave himself up completely in the in- terests of his neighbor to the writing of most excellent books, to the assisting of his brethren in their labors. He even divested himself of his garments in order to give them to the poor; he restored health to the sick, a fact which is proven by an incident which occurred in the Vatican Basilica on the Feast of Easter when he had preached, at which time he freed from a chronic hemorrhage a woman who had merely touched the hem of his garments.

In whom, We ask, is it possible to find in a more emi- nent degree than in the Angelic Doctor this "word of wisdom" so highly praised by St. Paul? St. Thomas did not think it enough merely to enlighten the intel- lects of men but sought in every possible way to turn their hearts toward love in return for such great love of man on the part of God, Who is the Cause of all things. "The love of God," he tells us in a sublime sentence, "is that virtue which infuses and creates goodness in all objects." (I, Q. XX, Art. 2) He never grew weary, in his treatment of the different mysteries of the Faith, of illustrating by each of them the mar- velous diffusion of the goodness of God. He wrote: "Tt is of the very nature of the Highest Good that He should communicate Himself to others in the highest

degree; God did this in a surpassing way in the mystery of the Incarnation." (III, Q. I, Art. 1)

Nothing perhaps proves more conclusively the efficacy of both his genius and charity than the Office of the Blessed Sacrament which ne composed. What great love he always had during life for the Holy Eucharist is clearly brought out by the words he uttered on his deathbed, when receiving the Holy Viaticum he said: "T receive Thee, price of the redemption of my soul, out of that love by means of which I have studied, watched, and labored."

After this brief survey of the principal virtues of Thomas it cannot but be an easy task to appreciate the excellence of his teachings which possess for the Church an authority and value without parallel. Our Predecessors are a unit in approving his teachings and always in the highest possible terms. Alexander IV did not hesitate to write the following to Thomas himself: "To our beloved son, Thomas Aquinas, a man superior because of the nobility of his birth and the purity of his morals, and who, by reason of the grace of God, suc- ceeded in acquiring a veritable treasure of divine and human knowledge." After his death John XXII ap- peared to wish to canonize at one and the same time both the teachings and virtues of Thomas when, on the occasion of an address to the Cardinals assembled in Consistory, he gave expression to this remarkable sentence: "He was the light of the Church more than

any other doctor; the man who studies his writings even for one year will profit more thereby than another who during his whole lifetime concentrates on the teachings of other doctors."

The fame of his genius and of his superhuman knowl- edge was so great that St. Pius V inscribed him among the Doctors of the Church and confirmed his title of Angelic Doctor. In conclusion, does any other fact prove more conclusively the high esteem in which the Church has always held this great Doctor than that of placing together upon the altar during the Council of Trent two and only two volumes, the Summa Theolo- gica and the Bible, as the sources of inspiration for the Fathers there assembled?

It is unnecessary to cite one by one the innumerable documents of the Holy See relative to this subject. There exists, however, fresh in Our minds the re- membrance of the renaissance of the teachings of St. Thomas brought about by the authority and zeal of Leo XIII. So much fame has this action brought to Our Illustrious Predecessor that, as We have said many times before, that act alone would have been sufficient to bring everlasting glory to him even if he had not accomplished and commanded so many other important and great works. We follow, too, in the footsteps of Pius X of saintly memory, and particularly his Motu Proprio Angelici Doctoris where We find this beauti- ful thought: "Since the blessed death of the Holy Doc- tor there has never been held in the Church an Ecu-

menical Council at which he did not assist by virtue of his precious teachings." Our immediate and much lamented Predecessor, Benedict XV, demonstrated more than once the selfsame respect for St. Thomas. To Benedict there has fallen the honor of promulgating the Code of Canon Law, in which the method, the teachings, and the principles of the Angelic Doctor are fully approved. (Can. 1366, par. 2)

While We re-echo the chorus of praises bestowed on that great genius, St. Thomas, We not only approve of the fact that he is called the Angelic Doctor, but We bestow at the same time upon him the title Universal Doctor, since the Church has made her own his teachings as can easily be proven by a multitude of documents. It would take too much space to set out at length the reasons advanced by Our Predecessors for such a decision. Suffice it here to point out that, Thomas wrote inspired by the supernatural grace which con- trolled his whole life, and that his writings, in which are expounded the principles and norms of all the sacred sciences, must be looked upon as of universal applicability.

In his treatment of divine things, both in his teaching and in his writings, he presented to theologians an illuminating example of the close relations which ought to exist between one's studies on the one hand and one's spiritual life on the other.

As we cannot truly say that a person possesses a precise knowledge of a far-distant country merely by

having read even exact and detailed accounts of it, for to become intimately acquainted with it there is re- quired a long residence in that country, so no one is able to acquire an exact knowledge of God merely by diligent scientific research unless at the same time he be united with Him in perfect union. Now, the con- trolling purpose of every part of the theology of St. Thomas is precisely to enable us to lead a life of closer intimacy with God Himself. Just as he never tired, while a boy at Monte Cassino, of asking himself the question "Who is God?", so the books written by him on such subjects as the Creation, Man, the Law, the Virtues, and the Sacraments all treat of God principally as the Author of our eternal salvation.

In discussing the causes which so often make our studies ineffective, as for example, curiosity or an immoderate desire of acquiring knowledge, bluntness of intellect, aversion to hard work, and lack of perseverance, he found the remedy for such limitations

solely in a most exact promptness where every task is concerned, a promptness vitalized by a love of piety and itself derived from the spiritual life. If theological study is guided by a threefold light, by the light of right reason, of infused faith, and by the gifts of the Holy Ghost, which gifts assist and perfect the operations of the intellect, certain it is that no one possessed this light more abundantly than Thomas, for after he had spent all the power of his great intellect on a par- ticularly difficult problem, and in vain, he sought in all

humility from God the answer to these questions by means of fastings and prayer. God heard his prayers, and so benignly, that at times He even sent the Princes of the Apostles to teach Thomas the truth. Nor is it wonderful that Our Saint had reached towards the close of his life such a high degree of contemplation that his writings seemed to him, as he said, to be but straw. He was accustomed also to say that he could not dictate any longer. His thoughts were so concentrated on eternal truth that his one remaining desire was to see God. Such all-encompassing love of God and such great desire for the things of eternity are the prin- cipal effects, as St. Thomas himself teaches us, which we too should obtain from our theological studies. While his example is a great lesson how we must conduct ourselves when we study a subject, he also instructs us by means of stable and firm principles how we must approach any particular science. To be spe- cific, who has explained better than St. Thomas the na- ture and the subject-matter of philosophy, the relations of the different parts of philosophy to one another, and the importance of each of them? The following quota- tion illustrates well the profundity of his thought where he points out the agreements and harmony which exist between the various organs which go to make up what one might call the body of philosophy. He writes: "It is the work of the philosopher to bring about order. The reason for this statement is that wisdom or philosophy is the perfect product of human reason,

whose peculiar province it is to understand such order. The faculties of sense, it is true, know some things in an absolute manner, but the order which exists between these things is known only by the intellect and reason. Therefore, there exist different sciences according as there exist different orders which human reason con- siders. That order which reason actually brings into existence in its own acts is the order of rational philosophy, or logic. The province of logic is to study both the order which exists between the different ele- ments of human discourse and the order which exists between the principles of thought viewed as principles or in the conclusions drawn from them. It is the function of natural philosophy, physics, to study the order which exists among objects in the universe, an order which reason studies but does not create; natural philosophy so viewed includes the study of metaphysics. The order which exists in the world of human acts is the subject-matter of moral philosophy, which may be divided into three parts: the first part studies the acts of the in- dividual as they lead to the achievement of his end and is called monistics; the second studies the acts of the domestic or family world and is called economics; the third studies the acts of the political world and is called politics." (Ethics, Lect. 1) St. Thomas expounded with all care these different parts of philosophy, each according to its own method, commencing with those subjects most closely related to human reason and then passing to those more remote from

it, until finally he arrived at the "very summit of all things." (Contra Gentiles, II, Chap. LVI and IV, Chap. I)

The teachings of St. Thomas with reference to the value of human thought are beyond all controversy. He writes: "The human intellect by its own native power knows Being and everything which is a part of Being as such. On this knowledge we base our understanding of first principles." This doctrine destroys at their very roots the errors and opinions of those con- temporary philosophers who deny that the intellect can perceive Being and contend that all we can possibly know are modifications of our own thoughts. Agnosti- cism, which was so roundly condemned by the encycli- cal Pascendi, has flowed precisely from these errors.

The arguments which St. Thomas used to prove the existence of God and that He alone is subsistent Being itself are today, as they were in the Middle Ages, the most valid proofs of these doctrines; arguments which offer at the same time a solid confirmation of the dog- mas of the Church solemnly proclaimed by the Council of the Vatican and which are so well interpreted by Pius X in the following words: "God, the beginning and end of all things, can be known and his existence can be proven with all certainty by the unaided light of reason by means of created things, that is to say, by means of the visible work of creation, as we know with assurance a cause from the study of its effects." (Sac- rorum Antistitum, 1 Sept. 1910) The metaphysical

teachings of St. Thomas, despite the fact that they are attacked frequently even today, retain all their cogency and brilliancy like gold which no acid can dissolve. Our Predecessor, Pius, well concludes with

this added thought: "We cannot depart any distance from the teachings of St. Thomas, especially in metaphysics, without incurring grave loss." (Encyclical Pascendi, 8 Sept. 1907)

Philosophy is the queen of the sciences. However, given the present order of Divine Providence, we cannot call it the first or most excellent science for the reason that it does not include the study of all things viewed from every possible angle. St. Thomas proves, both at the beginning of the Summa Theologica and of the Summa Contra Gentiles, that there exists an order superior to nature and which, therefore, surpasses the powers of human reason, an order of which man would never have known the existence had it not been re- vealed to him by the good God. This order is the field of faith, and the science of faith is theology. He who possesses the more profound acquaintance with the documents of faith, together with a full and highly developed faculty of philosophizing, he it is who understands best this science. It is beyond question that the science of theology was carried to its highest perfection by St. Thomas for he possessed at one and the same time a perfect knowledge of the divine documents of the faith and a marvelous genius peculiarly adaptable to the task of philosophizing. Wherefore St.

Thomas is the chief master of all Catholic schools not only because of his philosophical teachings, but es- pecially because of his theology. There exists no part of the wide field of theology in which he did not happily and successfully exercise the extraordinary richness of his mental gifts.

He founded on secure and incontrovertible foundations the science of apologetics by reason of the sound distinction which he made between faith and reason, between the natural and supernatural order. Thus, the Vatican Council, on the occasion when it defined that certain truths of religion can be discovered and known by human reason but that it is morally impossible to know without error all the truths of religion unless they had been revealed, and that as far as the mysteries of religion are concerned, a divine revelation is absolutely necessary, used the arguments not of other theologians but of St. Thomas. The Angelic Doctor al- ways held firmly to the principle that those who take upon themselves the task of defending the doctrines of the Church should remember that "to assent to the truths of faith, despite the fact that they surpass human reason, is not a matter to be taken lightly." (Contra Gentiles, I, Chap. 6) As a matter of fact, he proved that, although the object of faith may be obscure in itself and hidden from us, nevertheless the reasons which induce a man to accept the faith are clear and easily recognizable, since "no one would believe unless he perceived that the truths in question should be be-

lieved in." (II-II, Ques. I, Art. 4) He adds that the Faith, far from being a burden to humanity or a yoke of bondage imposed upon us, must be esteemed a great benefit since the "Faith is for us but the beginning of life eternal." (De Veritate, Ques. XIV, Art. 2)

The remainder of theology, which deals with the in- terpretation of dogma, was done by St. Thomas in a singularly remarkable way. No other writer has so penetrated the very depths of this subject or expounded in more accurate fashion the august mysteries of the Faith, and in particular the mysteries of the intimate life of God, of the secrets of eternal predestination, of the supernatural government of this world, of the power conferred on rational creatures of achieving each his fmal end, of the work of the Redemption of mankind by Jesus Christ, which is continued in the Church by the sacraments, two means of salvation which St. Thomas looks upon as, in a cer- tain fashion, "relics of the Divine Incarnation."

He outlined, too, a sound moral theology, one which directs with sureness the acts of man to the attain- ment of his supernatural end. Viewing his subject- matter as the perfect theologian which he was should, he did not fail to assign not only to individuals but to domestic and civil society as well those sure prin- ciples of life upon which are based the sciences of ethics, economics, and politics. Thus in the second part of the Summa Theologica we may find chapters which are unsurpassed on such subjects as the power and

rights of the father, the so-called. domestic rights, on the rights of the state and of the nation, on natural rights and international law, on peace, war, justice, and prop- erty rights, on laws and their observance, on the duty of working for our individual welfare and for the welfare of the public. All these subjects he treats not only from the side of the natural but of the supernatural order as well. If these teachings of his were exactly and re- ligiously observed by all men, both in their public and private lives, nothing else would be required to bring about among men that "peace of Christ in the King- dom of Christ" for which the whole world so ardently sighs. There is this further reason that it is most de- sirable that we understand and appreciate more and more the teachings of St. Thomas on the rights of na- tions and on the laws which regulate the relations of peoples one with another, since these doctrines contain the

true foundations for what is called today a "League of Nations." nn

His ascetic and mystical writings are no less valuable than his other works. Having first reduced the entire science of ethics to the rule of the virtues and of the gifts of the Holy Spirit, he defines in a marvelous way his teachings on this subject for the divers classes of men, for those who wish to live according to the ordi- nary rules of life, as well as for those who deliberately set out to attain Christian perfection and the fulness of the spiritual life in both of the two manners of life in which Christian perfection is found; namely, the

active and the contemplative life. Whoever would care to learn how the law of God's love grows in us, as char- ity and the gifts of the Holy Ghost, which are inti- mately associated with it, are increased, how the differ- ent states of life differ one from the other, what the state of perfection is, the religious state, the apostolate, and what is the exact nature of each, as well as other aspects of ascetical and mystical theology, such a man must go, first of all, to the Angelic Doctor for this in- formation.

He was most particular to base all his teachings on the Sacred Scriptures. Convinced that the Bible was in each and every one of its parts the word of God, St. Thomas insisted that we interpret it according to the selfsame rules which Our Predecessors, Leo XIII, in the encyclical Providentissimus Deus, and Benedict XV, in the encyclical Spiritus Paraclitus, laid down. Given the principle that "the Holy Spirit is the prin- cipal author of the Sacred Scriptures . . . man, the writer, being but an instrument of God" (Quodlib., VII, Art. 14, Ad. 5), it follows that no one can doubt the historical authority of the Biblical recitals. Accept- ing as a foundation for interpretation the normal signif- icance of a word, that is to say, its literal meaning, St. Thomas was able to derive therefrom all the varied richness of the spiritual sense which embraces, as he has shown, the threefold type of interpretation, the allegorical, the topological, and the anagogic.

In conclusion, our Saint possessed the gift and

singular privilege of being able to translate his scien- tific doctrines into prayers and hymns for the sacred li- turgy. He thus became the great poet and herald of the Blessed Eucharist. The Catholic Church most sol- emnly uses and always will use, all over the world and among all nations in her sacred rites these songs of St. Thomas from which there is exhaled the highest fervor of the soul in its approach to God by means of prayer and which contain at the same time the most precise expression of our traditional teachings concerning the August Sacrament, which belief assuredly merits to be called the Mystery of Faith par excellence. Considering all these things and recalling to memory the praise of St. Thomas uttered by Christ Himself, to which We called attention already in this letter, no one need be surprised that there has been bestowed upon him also the title of Eucharistic Doctor.

From all that has been written up to this point, We draw these practical conclusions. Above everything else it is necessary that our youth take St. Thomas as their especial model and that they try to imitate and follow as carefully as possible the great virtues which stand out so prominently in his life, and in particular the virtues of humility, the ground of the spiritual life, and of purity. They can learn from this man's life, he who had no equal in intellect, and, from his teachings, how to restrain every movement of pride, how to implore humbly upon their studies an abundance of the light of God. From this teacher, too, they can

learn how to flee with all their power from the allure- ments of pleasure so that they may be able to con- template the truth with a clear vision. These truths St. Thomas teaches in his own life not only, but also theoretically, for he has written: "If a man abstain from sensual delights in order to give himself up the more completely to a study of the truth, such a one acts according to right reason." (II-II, Ques. CLVII, Ad. 2)

The Sacred Scriptures likewise admonish us that, "wisdom will not enter into a malicious soul nor dwell in a body subject to sin." (Wisdom i, 4) If in the extreme danger in which St. Thomas was placed, his chastity had not conquered, it is probable that the Church would never have had an Angelic Doctor. When We, therefore, behold the majority of youth, seduced by the attractions of pleasure, throw overboard so quickly their purity and give themselves up to the delights of the senses, We, Venerable Brothers, exhort you from the depths of Our heart to propagate every- where, and especially among the younger clergy, the society called the 'Angelic Warfare," a society founded for the purpose of preserving and guarding the virtue of purity under the protection of St. Thomas. We confirm all the pontifical indulgences with which this society has been enriched by Benedict XIII and by all Our Predecessors. In order that everyone may be in- duced the more readily to become a member of the "Angelic Warfare," We grant the faculty to its mem-

bership instead of wearing the cincture, to carry sus- pended from the neck a medal which represents

on one side the picture of St. Thomas girded by angels and on the other, that of the Blessed Virgin, Queen of the Most Holy Rosary. : Since St. Thomas has been peeaimed the Patron of all Catholic schools, he who possessed in his person a twofold wisdom, one acquired by the use of reason and the other given him by God, who in order to solve most difficult problems united prayer with fasting, who regarded the image of Jesus Christ Crucified as his sub- stitute for all books, it is necessary that our youth consecrated to the service of God learn from him how they must comport themselves in their higher studies so that they may from these studies draw greater and more lasting fruit. The members of religious orders should always keep before themselves as a mirror the life of St. Thomas; he refused to accept all dignities even the highest in order that he might the more easily live a life of perfect obedience and die in the holiness of his religious profession. All the faithful, in conclu- sion, have in him an example of the most tender devo- tion toward the August Queen of Heaven. St. Thomas was accustomed often to recite the Angelical Salutation and to inscribe the sweet name of Mary in his books. They should ask, too, from the Eucharistic Doctor a great love like to his own for the Most Blessed Sac- rament of the Altar. Above all others the clergy should pray to him for such a gift. "Every day, unless pre-

vented by sickness, St. Thomas celebrated Holy Mass and afterwards assisted at the Mass of his companion or of some other priest. Oftentimes he even served Mass," as his diligent biographer informs us. Can any words express with what spiritual fervor he offered up the Holy Sacrifice, with what loving care he prepared for Mass, how after Mass was over he thanked the Divine Majesty for the great favors bestowed upon him?

In order to avoid the errors which are the primary source of all the evils of our times, it is necessary re- ligiously to hold fast, now as never before, to the teachings of the Angelic Doctor. He has given us a complete refutation of the erroneous views of the Mod- ernists. As regards philosophy, he has defended, as we have already seen, the value and power of human reason and has proven by unquestionably valid argu- ments the existence of God. As regards dogmatic theology, he has clearly distinguished the supernatural from the natural order and has placed in bold relief both the reasons for faith and the nature of Christian dogmas. In the field of pure theology he has shown that the articles of Faith are based not on mere opinion but on truth itself and are, therefore, unchangeable. In the Biblical sciences he has analyzed for us the true con- cept of divine inspiration. In the moral, social, and legal sciences he has laid down the exact principles on which legal and social justice, commutative and dis- tributive justice are founded and has explained fully

the relations of charity to justice. In ascetical theology he has formulated a doctrine on the perfection of the Christian life and victoriously refuted those who in his own age were opposed to the religious orders. In con- clusion, against that error so widely accepted today, which would make human reason independent of God, St. Thomas stoutly reaffirmed the rights of the First Truth and the authority over us of the Sovereign Mas- ter of all. From all of which it is easy to understand why the Modernists fear St. Thomas Aquinas more than any other doctor of the Church.

As in ancient times it was said to the Egyptians who found themselves in imminent danger of death, "Go to Joseph," in order that they might obtain from him the corn necessary to feed themselves and to save their lives, so now to those who pant after the truth We say, "Go to Thomas," for he possesses the truth in abundance and is able to lead us into the pastures of sound doctrine where we can obtain the spiritual food necessary for our souls' salvation. That this food exists and can be obtained by all was proven under the sanctity of an oath itself on the occasion when there was question of inscribing the name of St. Thomas in the catalogue of the saints of God's Church. "Because of his succinct, easy, and clear methods, many teachers both religious and secular have flourished under the egis of the luminous and logical teachings of this Doctor. . . . Even laymen and people of no great in- tellect wish to possess his writings."

Now We desire in particular that those professors who teach in seminaries the higher studies to the clergy should profoundly reflect upon and faithfully follow all the prescriptions of Leo XIII (Encyclical Hterni Patris) and of Pius X (Motu Proprio, Doctoris An- gelict, 29 June, 1914) and especially those which We Ourselves formulated last year. They should be con- vinced that they will live up to all their obligations and fulfill Our wishes if after they themselves have come to a great love of the Angelic Doctor by long and as- siduous study of his works, they communicate their own love of him to their pupils. lf they do this, their students will in turn be able to develop in others a love for the study of St. Thomas.

We desire that among the students of St. Thomas— and all Catholics who give themselves to higher studies should be his disciples—there should exist, within the limits of a reasonable freedom, an

honest rivalry which of itself makes so much for the progress of science. We at the same time desire that all invidious compari- sons be rigorously avoided since they are of no help to the cause of truth; in fact, they serve but to loosen the bonds of brotherly love which should bind all to- gether. All must, therefore, observe, and religiously, the prescriptions of the Code of Canon Law: "All pro- fessors must in their treatment of rational philosophy and of theology, and in their courses in these sciences, follow the method, the teachings, and the principles of the Angelic Doctor which are at all times to be strictly

observed." (Canon 1366, Par. 2) These professors, therefore, should so govern their work that in all things and in all truth St. Thomas can truthfully be said to be their master. No one, of course, may exact of professors either more or less than the Church, the mother and teacher of all, demands of them, for on those questions on which different authorities of our Catholic schools express different views and are not in agreement, cer- tainly no teacher can be compelled to accept an opinion which does not appear to him the more logical one. Therefore, as it is a matter of grave importance for the whole Church that this Centenary be worthily cele- brated, since by honoring St. Thomas it is not a ques- tion merely of the personal glory of a saint but of the authority itself of the Teaching Church, it is Our wish that every- where during this year from the eight- eenth of next July to the same day of the year follow- ing, this Centenary be observed, and especially in seminaries. We desire, too, that it be celebrated not only by the Friars Preacher, "that order, which," as Benedict XV wrote, "must be praised not so much for the fact that it gave the Angelic Doctor to the world, as that it has never even in the slightest de- parted from his teachings," but also by all other re- ligious orders and by all ecclesiastical colleges, schools, and universities of which St. Thomas is the heavenly ~ patron. It is only just that this Holy City of Rome, where St. Thomas passed some time as Master of the Sacred Palace, should be the first to celebrate this

feast. In order to exhibit their holy joy at this event, the Pontifical Collegio Angelico, where St. Thomas may be said to have lived as in his own home, and all the other ecclesiastical seminaries of Rome, should, by their observance of this Centenary, give an example to the other institutes of the world dedicated to the study of the sacred sciences.

In order to render more brilliant the celebration of this solemn Centenary and in order that greater fruits may flow from it, We grant by virtue of Our Apostolic authority the following privileges:

1. That in all churches of the Order of the Friars Preacher, and in all other churches or public chapels, or in chapels to which the public may be admit- ted, and especially in seminary, college, and school chapels, where a triduum, an octave, or a novena is held, the same indulgences may be gained which customarily are granted for similar functions in honor of saints or the beatified.

2. That during this Centenary in the churches of the Brothers and Sisters of the Dominican Order, but once only, the faithful having confessed their sins and received Holy Communion, may gain a Plenary Indul- gence as often as they pray before an altar dedicated to St. Thomas.

3. Likewise, in the above mentioned churches of the Dominicans, the priests and tertiaries of that Or- der may, during the year of the Centenary, on

every Wednesday, or on the first free day of the week, celebrate Mass in honor of St. Thomas, using the Mass of his feast day, saying or omitting the Gloria and Credo according to the rite of that par- ticular day. We also concede both to those who say and to those who assist at these Masses a Plenary Indulgence under the usual conditions.

During this period there should be held in honor of the Angelic Doctor in all seminaries and other ec- clesiastical institutes a solemn disputation on a phil- osophical question or on some other important scien- tific subject. In order that, in the future, the feast of St. Thomas be celebrated in a manner befitting the feast of one who is the patron of all Catholic schools, We wish that on that day no classes be held and also that not only solemn Mass be celebrated but that, at least in all seminaries and religious houses, a disputation such as We have written about above take place.

In conclusion, in order that under the guidance of the Angelic Teacher of Aquin students may progress more and more in their studies to the glory of God and the welfare of the Church, We have added to this, Our Letter, the text of a prayer which he himself used and We recommend strongly that it be given wide pub- licity. To all who recite with devotion this prayer, We grant by Our authority for each recitation an In- dulgence of seven years and seven quarantines.

As a pledge of heavenly gifts and a token of Our

fatherly love, We grant from the depths of Our heart the Apostolic Blessing to you, Venerable Broth- ers, to the clergy, and to all the people entrusted to your care.

Given at Rome, at St. Peter's, the twenty-ninth day of June, the Feast of the Prince of the Apostles, in the year 1923, the second of Our Pontificate.

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